essay · 2026-10-13

pi profiles

Adrian Tame, writing for plicara labs · 2026-10-13 ·

Two pieces on one idea, kept together. **Part 1** is the practical one: a small launcher I built so Pi can keep a separate setup for each kind of work. **Part 2** is the why, and a hypothesis I would like to test.

part 1: a shelf for the agents you build

I have been lucky enough to use a lot of coding agents. I'd call myself a heavy user of all of them, but I definitely like some more than others. The one I keep coming back to as my main harness is Pi, and this part is about a small system I built on top of it, which I've called pi-profiles.

The short version: a profile is a separate Pi setup for a separate way of working. Think Chrome profiles, but for your coding agent. It is not only which tools are loaded. It is how much the agent does on its own, what it is allowed to touch and when it is supposed to stop. I have one profile for everyday work at the keyboard, one for long unattended runs and one I keep only for testing a single extension. I pick the one I want when I launch Pi, and my session history follows me between them.

what is pi?

Pi is a minimal coding agent harness. Out of the box it gives a model a small set of tools (read, write, edit, bash) and very little else. Everything beyond that comes from things you add: skills, slash commands, extensions and packages that other people publish (or yourself, obviously). The idea is that the people using the tool are the ones who decide what it should be. This is a very different philosophy from the more walled garden approach that tools like Claude Code or Codex take, and gives power back to power users.

The mainstream tools are moving towards more capability built natively into the product, and with it more lock-in. That makes sense for them. They are big companies and lock-in is part of the business. But it reminds me of what Apple did with AirPods. You can use AirPods with an Android phone, and they work, but the experience is nowhere near what you get with an iPhone, because a whole layer of capability sits on top that only works inside the ecosystem. Pi is going the other way: open, extensible and approachable.

It is very easy to create a tool right now. Code is cheap. What is hard is standing behind a product for a long time when everyone's capacity to experiment is basically infinite. The Pi team gave a talk at some point about, more or less, hating AI, which I found very funny and also a good way to understand the people behind this tool. They are down to earth, they keep things simple and they distrust these tools by default (the same ones they are building). In the harness world they feel almost like the counterculture.

If you have never used Pi, it also has its own tutorial, which is genuinely good and worth going through before anything else in this article.

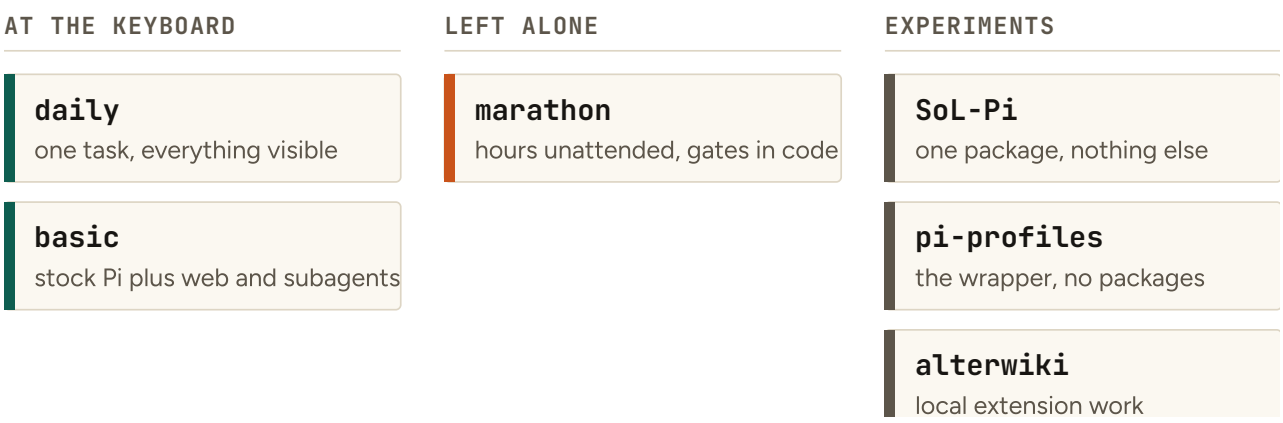
what pi profiles are

Pi solves a simple problem very well: you get to build your own agent. What it doesn't give you is a shelf to put those agents on.

Say you had a really good thing going with a particular setup. Or you want to set aside a configuration formally for one kind of task. Or you want to try a new skill or extension without it touching everything else. In plain Pi, your configuration is one directory, so every experiment changes the one agent you use for everything. The nature of Pi is extensibility and modularity, and that is great, but if you have nowhere to put the things you build, they are all a bit ephemeral.

Profiles are that shelf. Each one is a set of three kinds of pieces that you combine like Lego: skills, slash commands (which are like skills, except only you can invoke them) and extensions. You take the pieces you want for a job and leave the ones you don't. Pi is the tool, and profiles are the toolbox. Some days I need a screwdriver, some days a wrench and some days a hammer.

FIGURE 1. THE PROFILES ON MY SHELF



Six profiles, grouped by the kind of work each is for. Each one is a separate Pi setup, picked with one command when Pi starts.

These are the profiles I use right now:

profile	what it's for	what's in it
`daily`	Interactive, back-and-forth work at the keyboard, one task at a time.	Web access, subagents, a goal tracker, a visible to-do list and a few writing and document skills. No loops and no approval modes.
`basic`	Plain Pi, as it ships, with web search and subagents on top. Stock behaviour with the normal built-in tools, skills and prompts.	pi-web-access and pi-subagents. No lean extras from `daily`, no approval gating, no Ralph loop, and no default tools override.
`marathon`	Unattended work that runs for hours: deep research, long refactors, test coverage campaigns.	A goal workflow, Ralph loops, durable task plans, an approval gate and a code-review gate, plus written rules about worktrees, budgets and when to stop.
`SoL-Pi`	Testing NVIDIA's SoL-Pi on real work.	SoL-Pi and nothing else.
`pi-profiles`	Working on the pi-profiles wrapper itself: editing the code, testing a change, or running Pi with no packages at all to see what the base config does on its own.	No packages.
`alterwiki`	Developing the AlterWiki extension against my local checkout.	The AlterWiki extension, loaded from a local directory. That path only exists on my machine, so I would publish it as an npm or git package before packing this profile for anyone else.

The difference between `daily` and `marathon` is not just the number of tools. It is how the agent behaves. With `daily` I am in the loop the whole time. With `marathon` I might say "go and find every piece of research on this subject and tell me which ones I should read", and that could be a multi-step, multi-hour job I come back to later. That needs things I do not want anywhere near my daily work. A Ralph loop, for example, runs each iteration as its own Pi session, so Pi sessions have to be able to spawn other Pi sessions. That level of permission is fine for a supervised overnight run in a worktree. It is not something I am comfortable with in `daily`.

Most of what makes `marathon` safe to leave alone is code, not instructions. The audit loop refuses to record a clean review unless it has seen the tests pass since the last change. The Ralph loop is configured to block `git push` and to protect secrets. The profile's instructions say to work in a git worktree, to stop when a budget runs out or progress stalls, and to never declare success without running the acceptance commands fresh. The rules are written down, but the parts I rely on at three in the morning are enforced by extensions.

It also works the other way. `marathon` has a deep research workflow, and if those skills were loaded in `daily` they could trigger when I don't want them to. Deep research is its own part of the stack for me. Keeping it out of the profiles where I never want it is part of the point.

why `sol-pi` has a profile of its own

The `SoL-Pi` profile exists because of a mistake. When NVIDIA released SoL-Pi, I wanted to test it on long sessions, and my first attempt was the marathon stack plus SoL-Pi. One of the marathon extensions is pi-nolo, a permissions extension I needed for the loops. To do its job, pi-nolo re-registers Pi's built-in `edit` tool. SoL-Pi also extends `edit`, with a parameter that lets it fuse an edit and a follow-up command into one step. Whichever extension loads first keeps the `edit` slot, and pi-nolo was winning. So SoL-Pi's fusion feature never fired on a single edit for the whole trial.

Once SoL-Pi had a clean profile, I measured it again against stock Pi 0.85.1. With a natural prompt, the model never chose to use fusion: 0 of 6 runs. On small tasks that left the profile as ObservationPack plus about 14% extra prompt overhead. When the prompt asked for fusion, it fired every time and saved a turn (4 turns down to 3, with 21.6% and 12.7% fewer tokens). The large-context runs were too noisy to call with three pairs each. That is a small measurement, but it is a real one, and I could only get it once nothing else was in the way.

I didn't know that at the time. I actually opened an issue on SoL-Pi's GitHub thinking something was wrong with their system, when it was a compatibility problem between two extensions that are each fine on their own. That trial was useless, because I had changed more than one thing at

once. Now SoL-Pi lives in a profile with nothing else in it, and the profile's description says not to add anything that re-registers `edit`, `write` or `bash`.

That is the third reason I keep profiles, next to working style and context: controlled experiments. If you want to know what one extension does, you need a setup where it is the only thing that changed.

using it

The launcher is a single Bash script. Install it by putting it on your path:

```
ln -s "$PWD/bin/pi-profile" ~/.local/bin/pi-profile
```

The everyday commands:

```
pi-profile list                       # every profile, what it's for and
what it installs
pi-profile show marathon              # one profile's full description
pi-profile create work                # a new, empty profile
pi-profile create web --from work     # start from an existing profile's
settings
pi-profile create min --from base     # start from your normal Pi settings
pi-profile daily                      # launch Pi in the 'daily' profile
pi-profile                            # pick a profile interactively (fzf
if you have it)
```

Every profile carries a `DESCRIPTION.md`: what it is for and when to use it instead of another one. The first line is the summary that `list` and the picker show. Underneath that, `list` prints what the profile actually installs, read from the profile at that moment, so the description can never claim a package the profile doesn't have.

You can also share a profile. `pack` exports the portable parts into a folder you can push to GitHub, and `install` turns any such repository back into a local profile:

```
pi-profile pack marathon ./pi-marathon
pi-profile install you/pi-marathon
```

```
pi-profile install ./pi-marathon test   # local folders work too, to test
before pushing
```

Packages are not copied. They are fetched from npm or git the first time the profile launches, the same way Pi installs them normally. That also means installing someone else's profile runs their packages, so it carries the same trust as `npm install`. Read their `settings.json` first.

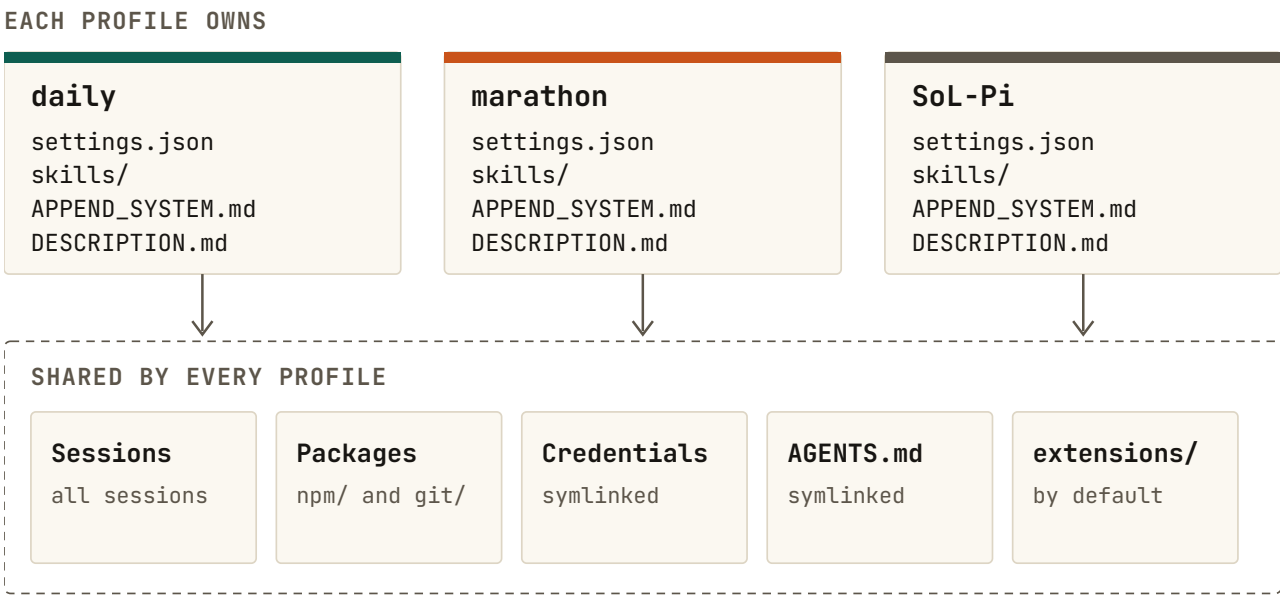
under the hood

This is the part I find most interesting, because the whole thing is small. Pi already has the two hooks the launcher needs. `PI_CODING_AGENT_DIR` tells Pi which directory to load its configuration from. `PI_CODING_AGENT_SESSION_DIR` tells it where to keep session history. Launching a profile is just:

```
export PI_CODING_AGENT_DIR="$HOME/.pi/profiles/$name"
export PI_CODING_AGENT_SESSION_DIR="$HOME/.pi/agent/sessions"
exec pi "$@"
```

Everything else in the script is about deciding which parts of a profile are its own and which parts are shared.

FIGURE 2. WHAT EACH PROFILE OWNS AND WHAT THEY SHARE



Pi reads its configuration from the directory the launcher points it at. Whatever lives in that directory is private to the profile. Everything inside the dashed box is shared by every profile, as one copy or a symlink. Extensions are shared by default because some tools install their own files there.

This is where each piece of a profile lives:

piece	where it lives	why
`settings.json` (packages, model, thinking level)	Each profile	This is what makes a profile different.
`skills/`	Each profile	Skills only load where you want them.
`APPEND_SYSTEM.md`	Each profile	Each profile's own instructions, added to the system prompt.
`DESCRIPTION.md`	Each profile	What it's for, shown by `list` and the picker.
Session history	Shared	`/resume` sees every session from every profile.

piece	where it lives	why
`auth.json`, `models-store.json`, `trust.json`	Shared, by symlink	Credentials live in one place and are never copied.
Global `AGENTS.md`	Shared, by symlink	My general instructions apply everywhere.
`extensions/`	Shared by default	Some tools install their own files here, and Pi only looks in the active directory.
Installed packages (`npm/`, `git/`)	One shared pool	One `pi update --extensions` updates every profile.

A few of those choices are worth explaining.

Sessions are shared. This is the main difference from most other profile tools, and it is an opinion, not a technicality. I am not trying to build separate agents that happen to run the same software. I want to change the working environment and keep the continuity of my work. If you would rather each profile be its own agent with its own memory, that is a reasonable choice too, and one of the packages below does exactly that. Pi keys session files by working directory, so in practice history is shared per project: I can start something in `daily`, decide it is a marathon job and resume the same thread there.

Extensions are shared by default. A private `extensions/` for each profile sounds cleaner, but it breaks things quietly. Some tools install their own files into Pi's base directory, and Pi only discovers extensions under the directory it is running from, so a profile with its own empty `extensions/` loaded none of them. If a profile really needs its own extensions, you replace the symlink with a real directory and link back in the ones you want.

Packages live in one pool. Pi installs packages under its agent directory. With several profiles that would mean several copies of everything and five updates every time something changes. Instead, every profile's `npm/` and `git/` directories are symlinks into one pool at `~/.pi/profiles/.shared/`, and the base Pi directory points there too. Each profile still declares its own list of packages in `settings.json`; it just doesn't keep its own copy of them.

Sharing is a whitelist. `pack` copies an explicit list of files (`settings.json`, `APPEND_SYSTEM.md`, `DESCRIPTION.md`, `sol-pi.json`) and directories (`skills/`, `prompts/`, `extensions/`), and it

never copies or follows a symlink. Credentials are always symlinks, so they can't end up in a bundle by accident. New config files get added to the list by name, never with a wildcard.

You can see where you are. New profiles get a tiny extension, `profile-badge`, that shows the profile name in Pi's footer. It reads `PI_CODING_AGENT_DIR`, so it stays quiet when Pi runs without the launcher.

It is also worth being clear about what the launcher does not do. It doesn't change Pi itself or override any of its behaviour. It doesn't switch anything inside a running session; you pick the profile when you start Pi. Skills in `~/.agents/skills/` are still loaded in every profile, because that is Pi's cross-harness skill location. A project's own `.pi/` folder still loads on top, as usual. And a profile is not a sandbox. It changes what the agent has available, not what it is allowed to touch on your machine. The limits in `marathon` come from its extensions and its rules, not from the profile.

other people are building this too

I'm not the only one who wanted this. There is a Pi issue proposing a built-in `--profile` flag on top of `PI_CODING_AGENT_DIR`, mostly to keep state such as credentials, sessions and settings separate between environments. People are still asking for it to be reconsidered, and as far as I can tell there is no plan for native profiles in Pi. And there are several packages that each mean something slightly different by a profile:

project	when the profile changes	session history	what it focuses on
pi-profiles (mine)	At launch	Shared	Reusable setups for different kinds of work, and controlled experiments
pi-profile-switch	During a session, without restarting	Kept while switching	Choosing skills, extensions, MCP servers and tools per workflow
pi-profile	During a session	Kept while switching	Swapping model, skills, subagents and system prompt
@sovorn/pi-profile	At launch	Separate per profile	Isolated profiles, each with its own memory

These come from each project's own description, and they will probably have changed by the time you read this. I don't think one of them is right and the others wrong. If you want to change

modes in the middle of a session, a runtime switcher is more convenient. If you want a clear boundary around what is loaded and the same history everywhere, launching into a profile is simpler. That so many people built some version of this independently says something, though. It is in the nature of this tool that people extend it to fit the way they work.

If you want to try mine, the code and my profiles are at github.com/AdrianTJ/pi-profiles. Make it fit the way you work. That is the whole point of Pi.

part 2: agents, plural

A while ago I noticed that every Pi session I started was already 15 to 20% full before I had typed anything. One of my extensions, a to-do tracker, was loading a huge amount into context on every start. It was useful, but it was absolutely massacring my ability to work on anything else. Debugging that, and working out which other extension could do the same job, is how I ended up building Pi profiles, which is what part 1 above describes.

This piece is about why I work that way, and where I think it is all heading. The practical side, how the launcher works, is in part 1. This one is the why.

pi, and the people it is for

Pi is a pretty beautiful system. It is useful, it is extensible, it is open by design and it lets you play. And we are in an era where you can use AI tools to build the system with itself, which is a bit crazy when you think about it. A tool that builds itself is a very interesting idea, and it is really how Pi is meant to be used.

The other harnesses are powerful too. Claude Code, Codex, Cursor, Goose, and a long tail of smaller ones. There is even Oh My Pi, which is built on Pi and goes in the opposite direction: a ton of functionality, a ton of skills, everything switched on. I like it and I use it quite a bit. But for me it is overkill, and it cuts against what I think Pi is about.

There is a lot of excitement around Pi among the people I talk to who build systems. It is the same kind of person who got excited when TypeSafe released Jev, or who goes deep into LazyVim. Engineers who like to work with their tools, take them apart and modify them. There is always going to be a place for those people and for the work they do.

That is a very different kind of user from someone using a mainstream application where the decisions are made for you. It is the Linux crowd versus the Mac crowd. I'm not arguing about the merits of either, whether you're on a Mac or on a 14-year-old ThinkPad that is modded to high heaven. There is a need for both, and a beauty in both. Some people just want their tools to work

for them. Some people want modular control. Pi is for the second group, and its whole philosophy is minimalism plus extensibility by the people who use it.

the one thing i was missing

Pi is minimal, obviously, so I understand why some things are not in it. Durability is a good example. Pi Durable is an incredible direction and very interesting, but it is also very opinionated, so it lives separately from the minimal core. That is the right call, and long unattended runs are exactly where it matters.

The one thing I felt was actually missing from Pi was the ability to keep more than one agent: to create profiles and move between them. So I built my own. I am not saying it is for everyone. I am saying it is for me, and that is the point of Pi. Several other people have built their own versions, which tells me I'm not the only one who wanted it.

The to-do extension was the first push. Testing was the second. Ponytail is a popular extension, and a good one, but it changes the agent's behaviour quite drastically, and with everything else loaded alongside it I couldn't tell what it was doing to my setup. Then NVIDIA released SoL-Pi and I wanted to try it on long sessions. I tried it inside my normal setup, and another extension silently switched off its main feature for the whole trial. I even opened an issue on their GitHub before I realised it was my setup, not their code (the full story is in the other article). I had changed more than one thing at once, and the trial told me nothing.

a lab, not a single stream

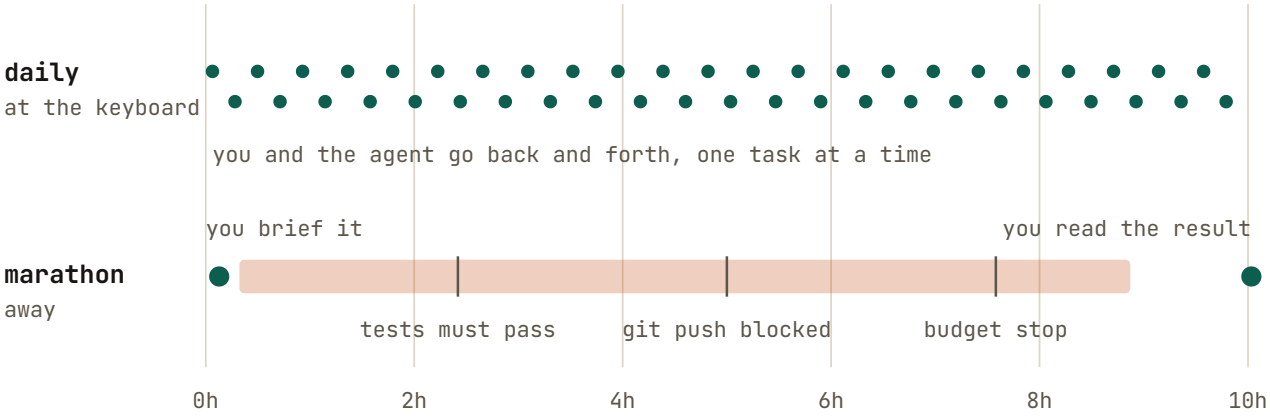
Native Pi in its minimalism is absolutely beautiful, but it is also restrictive. Some people will like that. What I want is a lab. The way I think is more like a laboratory than a single stream of work. I want to isolate environments, test one thing at a time and separate tasks by profile.

Pi is a generalist tool, which is part of the point. But sometimes you need a specialised one. A screwdriver will take ten times less effort than trying to do the same job with a hammer, if a hammer is all you have. People talk about Pi as a Swiss army knife. I don't think it is one. It is a very simple stick that you build into something useful to you. I want to build many things that are useful to me.

The difference between my profiles is not really the tools. It is the way of working. `daily` assumes I am in the loop the whole time: back and forth, one task, everything visible. `marathon` assumes I am gone for ten hours, so it needs things I don't want anywhere near my daily work, like Pi sessions that can spawn other Pi sessions, an approval mode that won't stop at 3am, and hard

rules about budgets, worktrees and when to give up. Those are different permissions and different failure modes. Putting them in one configuration makes both worse.

FIGURE 3. TWO WAYS OF WORKING



An illustration of how the two profiles are meant to be used, not a measurement. With `daily` I am in the loop the whole time. With `marathon` I leave it, so the rules I rely on are checks that run in code.

This is the one place where I disagree with the philosophy of the team behind Pi, and I'm probably the only one. It is not agent, singular. It is agents, plural. If you really want to get into Pi, profiles are a necessary part of that learning journey, because you need to be able to test things out.

isn't this the opposite of minimalism?

The obvious objection is that more profiles means more configuration to maintain, which is exactly what Pi is trying to avoid. I think it is the other way around. The alternative to several small profiles is not one small profile. It is one large profile that slowly accumulates everything you have ever found useful, until it looks like Oh My Pi.

Profiles let each setup stay minimal. My SoL-Pi profile has one package. `daily` has seven. `marathon` has eleven, because unattended work needs more machinery. None of them carries the others' tools. The complexity moves from what is loaded to what you choose, and choosing is the part I want to be deliberate about anyway.

There is a second opinion baked in that is worth naming: my profiles share session history. I care more about the continuity of my work than about keeping agents apart. I can start something in `daily`, realise it is a marathon job and pick up the same thread there. Other people want each profile to be its own agent with its own memory, and that is a fair choice too. It is just not mine.

the models got good

The other part of this is that the models keep getting better. Something people forget, and I forget too, is that this is the worst these models will ever be.

At some point this year the models crossed a line for me. They understand context well enough to do what you mean without careful wordsmithing. I like to talk things through, and most of what I write, including this article, starts as a voice conversation with an agent: bouncing ideas around, arguing, recording. That only works because the models now follow a messy spoken explanation.

So here is a strong claim. I think prompt engineering is basically dead, and the skills way of working is going with it. If you came into these tools today with no skills and none of the old habits, I suspect you would get better results than someone carrying over everything from six months or a year ago. Boris, who created Claude Code, recently shared how he prompts it, and it is about as basic as a prompt gets: build me a game. And it works. What matters now is harness and context engineering.

That is my experience. It is not yet evidence, and I would not accept it from anyone else on those terms. But some of the evidence I do have points the same way.

FIGURE 4. DO MODELS READ SKILLS?

Before the edit: 7 of 21 sessions opened the skill file



Right after I put the rule there: 0 of 3

opened SKILL.md did not

One square per session in my Pi Audit Loop experiments. Small numbers from one setup, so this is an observation, not a proof.

- **Models often don't read skills.** In my earlier Pi Audit Loop experiments, 7 of 21 sessions opened the bundled skill files at all, and 0 of 3 did right after I put an important rule there. Moving it into a tool description and a tool message, at the point where the model had to act on it, was what got it in front of the model at all, and even then it did not reliably change what the model did.
- **The guarantees I rely on are code.** In `marathon`, the review gate refuses a clean verdict unless the tests ran since the last change, and the loop blocks `git push`. Those are extensions. The written rules in that profile matter, but they are not what I trust when nobody is watching.
- **The context cost is real.** The to-do extension at the start of this piece is the clearest case I have. Every skill, tool definition and extension takes up context and can trigger when you don't want it to.

None of that proves skills are fading in general. It is one person's setup and a few small experiments. So the honest version of my claim is a hypothesis: skills will stop encoding ways of working and mostly encode taste, how you like things done, while the important parts move into hooks, extensions, permissions and slash commands you invoke at a particular moment.

That is testable. When I wrote that the harness is the signal, the idea was to watch what we build around models to understand what they can and cannot do. The same approach works here. The GitSkills dataset has about 3.8 million `SKILL.md` files from 282,200 public repositories, and it is what my earlier articles on the languages skills are written in were built on. If I'm right, I'd expect skill files to shift over time from procedures towards preferences, and hooks and extensions to grow alongside them, especially among people who actively customise their harnesses. If I'm wrong, the data should show that too. That is the next piece.

become a harness engineer

There is a call to action here regardless of how that test comes out. The way Pi was created, the philosophy of the team and the purpose of the tool make it a very useful base for everything. But it also forces you to think about context engineering. In Pi you see the cost of every skill and extension, because you put each one there yourself. I'd love to have every skill and extension loaded for free, but that isn't how it works.

If you want to become a harness engineer and actually think about these problems, the tool you need is something like Pi. Instead of building software by importing libraries, you are designing the harness and the agents that help you through the work.

So design the environment, not just the prompt. And keep more than one.